

# Perspective

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**B**efore the Renaissance, artists attempting to show distance on flat surfaces, simply made some objects smaller than others, with no uniform technique. But in the Early Renaissance, a mathematical method for creating the illusion of distance was rediscovered. 'Linear perspective' helped painters represent the world around them as realistically as possible. Lines converge to meet at a vanishing point on the horizon, and objects become smaller as they recede towards that point. Some images have more than one vanishing point, but the same rules apply.

Brunelleschi is believed to have worked out the method c.1410–15, after visiting Rome with Donatello a few years before. Its impact was immeasurable. In 1435, the artist Leon Battista Alberti (1404–72) wrote of perspective in his treatise, *On Painting*. According to art historian Giorgio Vasari, Paolo Uccello (1397–1475) stayed up all night working it out. Aerial perspective, meanwhile, is the atmospheric effect of distant objects appearing bluer and less distinct than closer objects.



Ghirlandaio, *The Visitation*, 1491